
LaunchStage guide

Your whole workspace in one press. Version 0.2.0.

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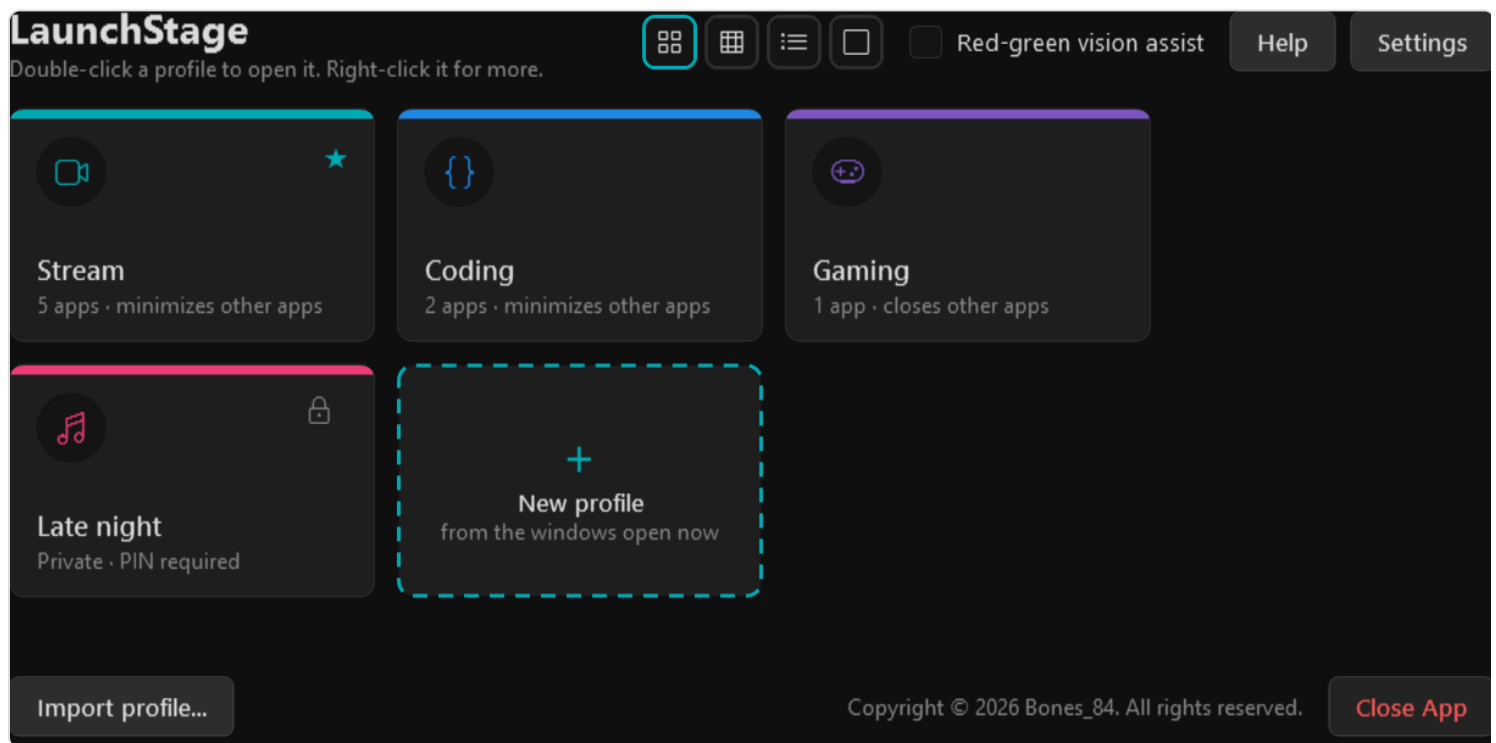
What LaunchStage does

LaunchStage sets up your whole PC for one job with one press.

You make a **profile** for each thing you do, like *Stream*, *Coding* or *Gaming*. A profile remembers:

- which apps you need (OBS, Discord, a browser on your dashboard...)
- exactly where each window goes, on which monitor, and how big it is
- what happens to the apps you don't need: leave them, minimize them or close them

When you open the profile, LaunchStage opens the apps one at a time, waits until each one is ready, and puts every window in its spot. When you're done, closing the profile closes those apps again.



The LaunchStage window with a card for each profile

Tip: LaunchStage never force-closes anything. It closes apps the same way you would by clicking X, one at a time, and waits if an app asks to save your work.

Where to find it

- **The LaunchStage window:** one card for each profile. Double-click a card to open that profile.
- **The tray icon** (by the clock, bottom right): right-click it to open or close a profile without opening the window.

- **Hotkeys and button pads:** a key or a button for each profile. See Hotkeys and Stream Deck and other button pads.

Next: Make your first profile.

Make your first profile

A profile is made from the windows you have open right now, so set things up the way you like them first.

1. Open every app you want in the profile.
2. Put each window where you want it and make it the size you want. Use all your monitors if you like.
3. In LaunchStage, click the dashed **New profile** card.
4. Type a **Name**, like `Stream`.
5. Pick an **Icon** and a **Color** for the card.
6. Under **Apps not in this profile**, choose what happens to everything else: **Leave them alone**, **Minimize them** or **Close them**.
7. In the list of windows, tick each window that belongs to this profile.
8. Click **Save profile**.

Name

Stream

Icon

Aa

Color

Apps not in this profile ?

☐ Leave them alone

☒ Minimize them

☐ Close them (asks to save first)

☐ Open all apps at the same time (faster on powerful PCs; normally each app finishes loading before the next st

☐ Suggest a game when this profile is ready (shows a game picker with your Steam, Epic and added games)

☐ Private profile: needs a 4-digit PIN to open, close, edit, export or delete

Hotkeys ?

Open / close this profile

Clear

Put its windows back

Clear

Click a box and press the keys (use Ctrl, Alt or Win with a key, or F13 to F24 alone). They work anywhere while LaunchStage is running. The first opens this profile, or closes it if it's already open. The second puts its open windows back in their spots without opening or closing anything.

Apps: tick the windows that belong

Refresh list

Arrange your windows first. Each window's monitor, size and position are saved when you press Save.

☒ OBS Studio — OBS 31.0 - Profile: Stream - Scenes: Main
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

☒ Discord — #general | My Server - Discord

Cancel

Save profile

The New profile window: name, icon, color, and the windows to tick

That's it. Your new profile shows up as a card in the LaunchStage window.

Tip: Moved a window after you saved? No problem. You can change everything later. See Move and resize windows.

Good to know

- **Apps that are already open** are reused when the profile opens, just moved into place. LaunchStage only opens what's missing.
- **Apps that run as administrator** (some games, tools) need **Admin support**. Turn it on in **Settings**. See Settings and look.
- **Browser windows** can open on their own websites. See Browser windows and websites.

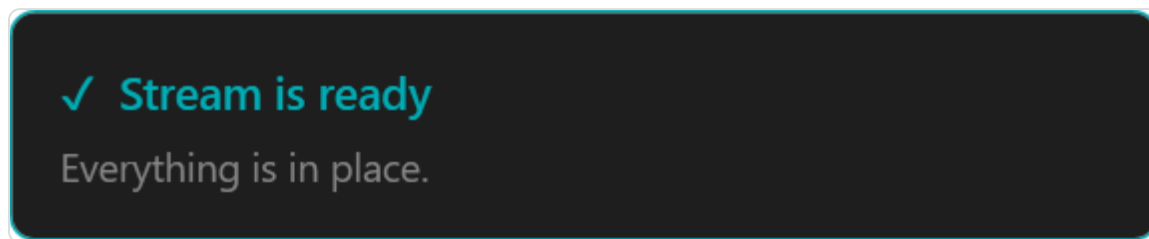
Open and close a profile

Open a profile

Any of these work:

- Double-click the profile's card in the LaunchStage window.
- Right-click the tray icon and click the profile's name.
- Press the profile's hotkey (see Hotkeys).
- Press its button on a Stream Deck or other button pad (see Stream Deck and other button pads).

A small box in the bottom-right corner shows what LaunchStage is doing, and says **is ready** when everything is in place.



The progress box in the corner of the screen

Tip: Wait for one profile to finish before opening another. While a profile is being set up, the cards are greyed out.

Close a profile

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Close profile**. (Or right-click the tray icon, then **Close a profile**.)
2. LaunchStage closes the profile's apps one at a time.
3. If an app asks "Save changes?", answer it. LaunchStage waits for you.

If an app doesn't close (for example, you clicked **Cancel** when it asked to save), the corner box asks what to do:

- **Try again:** asks the app to close once more.
- **Leave it open & continue:** skips that app and closes the rest.
- **Stop profile:** stops right there.

Apps you chose to keep open go back to where they were before the profile started.

Put windows back

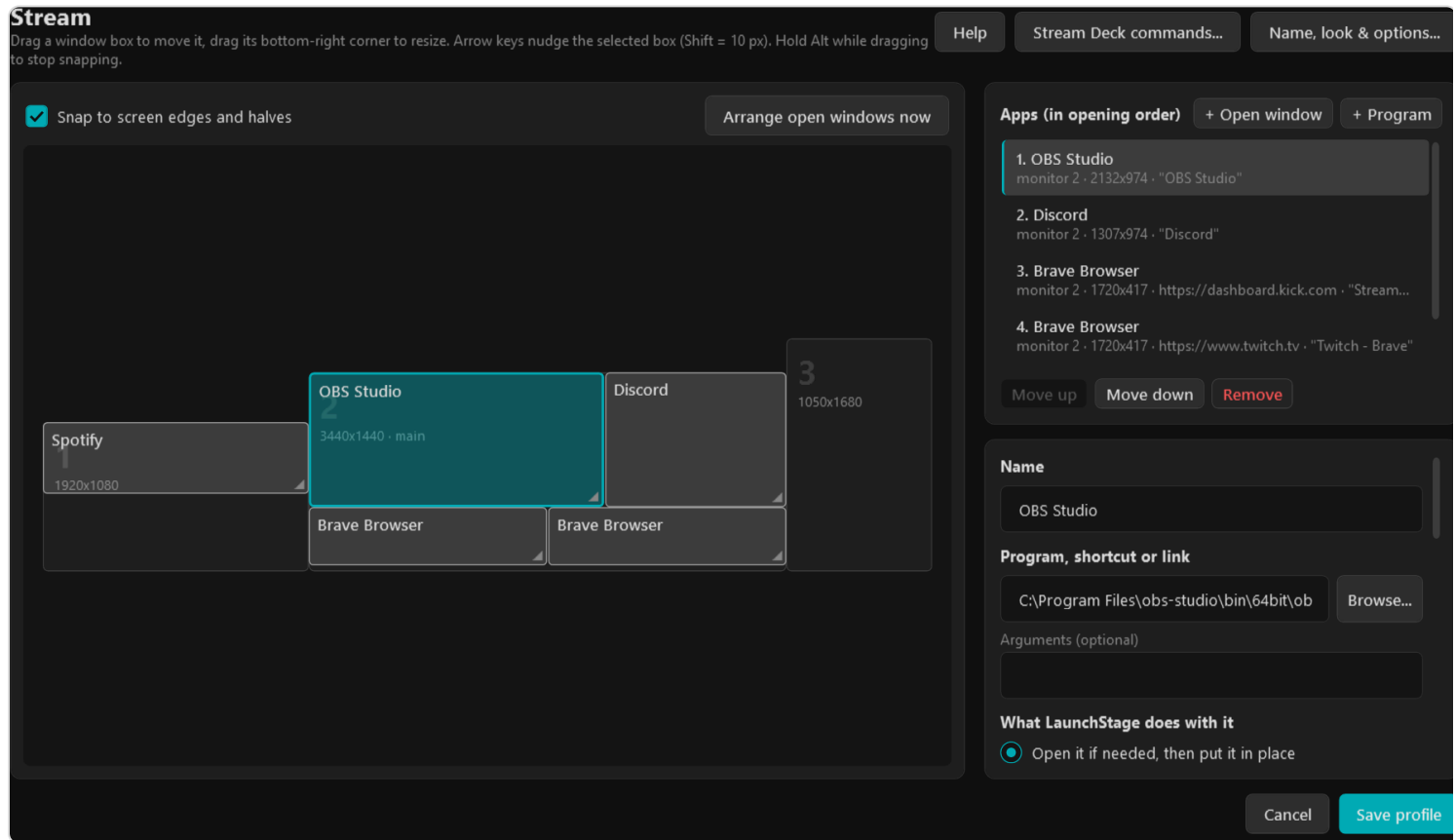
Dragged windows around during a session? Right-click the card and click **Put windows back**. Every open window of that profile jumps back to its spot. Nothing is opened or closed.

The card's right-click menu

Menu item	What it does
Activate	Opens the profile
Close profile	Closes the profile's apps
Put windows back	Moves the open windows back to their spots
Edit layout & apps...	Move windows, add or remove apps (see Move and resize windows)
Name, look & options...	Name, icon, color, options, hotkeys and PIN
Duplicate	Makes a copy to start a new profile from
Stream Deck commands...	Command lines for button pads and shortcuts
Add to favorites	Puts the card first, with a star
Export...	Saves the profile as a file to back it up or share it
Delete	Removes the profile (asks first)

Move and resize windows

Right-click a profile's card and click **Edit layout & apps....** You'll see your monitors drawn to scale, with a box for every window in the profile.



The Profile Editor: your monitors with a box for each window, and the app's settings on the right

Move a window

1. Drag its box to where the window should go.
2. To resize it, drag the box's bottom-right corner.
3. Click **Save profile**.

Boxes snap to the edges and halves of each screen. Hold **Alt** while dragging to turn snapping off. After clicking a box, the arrow keys nudge it 1 pixel (hold **Shift** for 10).

Try it out

- **Move it there now:** moves that app's open window to the spot, so you can see how it looks.
- **Use its current spot:** you moved the real window yourself? This copies where it is right now.

- **Arrange open windows now:** puts every open window of the profile in its spot. Nothing opens or closes.

Add, remove and reorder apps

- **+ Open window:** add a window that's open right now.
- **+ Program:** add a program or shortcut by its file.
- **Move up / Move down:** apps open in this order, top first.
- **Remove:** takes the app out of the profile.

Settings for one app

Click an app in the list (or its box) to see its settings on the right:

- **What LaunchStage does with it:** open it and put it in place, only put it in place if it's already open, or only open it.
- **Monitor**, and **Normal**, **Maximized** or **Minimized**.
- **Run as administrator**, and **Close it when the profile is closed**.
- **Wait before opening:** handy for apps that need another app to start first.
- **Websites** (browsers only). See Browser windows and websites.

Tip: Nothing is saved until you click **Save profile**. Close the window without saving and LaunchStage asks first.

Which apps close

Right-click a profile's card and click **Name, look & options....**

Apps (5 saved)

[Refresh list](#)

☐ Replace this profile's apps with the windows ticked below

Saved: OBS Studio, Discord, Brave Browser, Brave Browser, Spotify. To change them, arrange your windows, tick the box above and pick the windows below.

☐ OBS Studio — OBS 31.0 - Profile: Stream - Scenes: Main
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

☐ Discord — #general | My Server - Discord
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

☐ Brave Browser — Stream manager - Kick - Brave
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

☐ Brave Browser — Twitch - Brave
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

☐ Spotify — Spotify Premium
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

☐ File Explorer — Downloads - File Explorer
Monitor 1 · 1920x1080 · Normal

Run as administrator

☐ OBS Studio ☐ Discord ☐ Brave Browser ☐ Spotify

Ticked apps start with administrator rights. Turn on Admin support in Settings so Windows doesn't ask each time.

Open these browser windows as private / incognito ?

☐ Brave Browser: Stream manager - Kick - Brave

☐ Brave Browser: Twitch - Brave

Edge and Firefox private windows are ticked automatically. Chrome and Brave don't show it in the title, so tick those yourself.

When you close this profile, close ?

☒ OBS Studio ☒ Discord ☐ Spotify

Brave Browser has 2 windows. If closing its main window closes the others, tick only the main one.

☒ Stream manager - Kick - Brave

☒ Twitch - Brave

☒ Put the apps that stay open back where they were before the profile started

☒ Move windows back to their profile spots before closing them, so apps that remember their position don't re

Stream Deck commands...

Cancel

Save profile

Options for closing, hotkeys and more

Apps that aren't in the profile

Under **Apps not in this profile**, choose what happens when the profile opens:

- **Leave them alone:** nothing happens to them.
- **Minimize them:** they're tucked away to the taskbar.
- **Close them (asks to save first):** they're closed one at a time, and LaunchStage waits if one asks to save.

Apps that should never close

Some apps should never be closed or minimized by any profile, like a password manager or music player.

1. Open **Settings**.
2. Under **Never close**, start typing the app's name and pick it from the list. (Or click **Browse...** to find its program file.)
3. Click **Save**.

When you close the profile

Under **When you close this profile, close**, tick the apps that should close with the profile. Unticked apps stay open.

- **Put the apps that stay open back where they were before the profile started:** handy for apps like Discord that you use all the time.
- **Move windows back to their profile spots before closing them:** apps that remember their own window position will remember the profile's layout, not where you last dragged them.

Apps with several windows

Some apps open several windows (like a chat overlay with a main window and chat boxes). An app like that gets one tick box per window. Tick only the **main** window: LaunchStage closes just that one, and the app closes its other windows itself.

Tip: Transparent Twitch Chat is handled for you: LaunchStage always closes its main window only, so your chat overlays are never deleted.

Browser windows and websites

Each browser window in a profile can open on its own websites, in its own window.

Set a window's websites

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Edit layout & apps....**
2. Click the browser window in the list.
3. In the **Websites** box, type the sites, one per line. Each one opens as a tab. (`kick.com` is fine; LaunchStage adds `https://` for you.)
4. Click **Save profile**.

Tip: Easier: open the browser on the site first, then click **Use the site it's showing now**. LaunchStage reads the address for you. When you add a browser window to a profile, it does this by itself.

Leave **Websites** empty and the browser shows whatever it normally shows when it starts.

Private / incognito windows

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Name, look & options....**
2. Under **Open these browser windows as private / incognito**, tick the windows that should be private.
3. Click **Save profile**.

A private window only ever uses or closes private windows. Normal windows leave private ones alone.

Which browsers work

Chrome, Brave, Edge, Firefox, Vivaldi, Opera and Opera GX, Chromium, Arc, Thorium, Zen, LibreWolf, Waterfox, Floorp and Mullvad Browser. Other browsers still open and get moved into place, just without the Websites box or private windows.

Hotkeys

A hotkey is a key combination, like `Ctrl+Alt+1`, that works anywhere in Windows while LaunchStage is running, even when it's hidden in the tray.

Give a profile hotkeys

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Name, look & options....**
 2. Under **Hotkeys**, click the **Open / close this profile** box.
 3. Press the keys you want, for example `Ctrl+Alt+1`. The box shows them.
 4. If you like, click the **Put its windows back** box and press another combination.
 5. Click **Save profile**.
- **Open / close this profile:** press it once to open the profile. Press it again to close it.
 - **Put its windows back:** moves the profile's open windows back to their spots.

A hotkey for the game picker

Open **Settings**, click the **Open the game picker** box under **Hotkeys**, press the keys, and click **Save**.

Rules for hotkeys

- Use `Ctrl`, `Alt` or `Win` together with a key. The keys `F13` to `F24` (found on many macro pads) also work on their own.
- Two hotkeys can't be the same. LaunchStage tells you if one is already used.
- If another program already uses a combination, LaunchStage tells you, so you can pick another.
- To remove a hotkey, click **Clear** next to it (or click the box and press `Backspace`).

Tip: A copy made with **Duplicate** starts without hotkeys, because a key can only do one thing.

Stream Deck and other button pads

Any button pad that can open a program can control LaunchStage: Stream Deck, Soomfon, macro pads, even a desktop shortcut.

Get the command for a button

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Stream Deck commands....**
2. Click **Copy** next to the command you want (see the list below).
3. In your button pad's software, add an action that opens a program or website, and paste the command.

The commands:

- **Open this profile**
- **Open or close this profile (one button for both)**
- **Close this profile**
- **Put its windows back in place**
- **Open the game picker**

Stream Deck commands for Stream

Paste one of these as the location of a new Windows shortcut (right-click the desktop, New, Shortcut), then pick that shortcut in Stream Deck's System > Open action. Stream Deck's Open action can also take the full line directly.

Open this profile

```
"C:\Program Files\LaunchStage\LaunchStage.exe" --activate "Stream"
```

Copy

Open or close this profile (one button for both)

```
"C:\Program Files\LaunchStage\LaunchStage.exe" --toggle "Stream"
```

Copy

Close this profile

```
"C:\Program Files\LaunchStage\LaunchStage.exe" --close "Stream"
```

Copy

Put its windows back in place

```
"C:\Program Files\LaunchStage\LaunchStage.exe" --resnap "Stream"
```

Copy

Open the game picker (any profile)

```
"C:\Program Files\LaunchStage\LaunchStage.exe" --games
```

Copy

LaunchStage program

```
C:\Program Files\LaunchStage\LaunchStage.exe
```

Copy

For tools that ask for the program and its arguments separately: use this as the program, and --activate "name", --toggle "name", --close "name", --resnap "name" or --games as the arguments. Works with any macro pad that can open a program (Stream Deck, Soomfon and others).

Close

The Stream Deck commands window

Tip: If your pad's software asks for the program and its arguments separately, copy the **LaunchStage program** line as the program, and use the part after it (like `--toggle "Stream"`) as the arguments.

LaunchStage doesn't even need to be open: the button starts it if needed. A private profile still asks for its PIN.

The Stream Deck plugin

If you have an Elgato Stream Deck (Stream Deck app 7.1 or newer), there's also a LaunchStage plugin with three buttons:

- **Profile:** pick a profile and what pressing does. The button lights up while the profile is open.
- **Put windows back:** pick a profile.
- **Play a game:** opens the game picker.

To install it, double-click the file `com.bones84.launchstage.streamDeckPlugin`, then drag the buttons from the **LaunchStage** group onto your Stream Deck. Open LaunchStage once first, and keep it running (in the tray is fine).

Game picker

The game picker lists your games so you can start one quickly.

Stream is ready. Play a game?

Double-click a game to start it.

Rocket League

Epic · played yesterday

★

Counter-Strike 2

Steam · played 2 hours ago

Elden Ring

Steam · played 6 days ago

Fortnite

Epic · not played from LaunchStage yet

Minecraft

Manual · not played from LaunchStage yet

Stardew Valley

Steam · not played from LaunchStage yet

+ Add game...

☐ Show hidden

Not now

Play

The Pick a game window

Open it

- Right-click the tray icon and click **Play a game...**
- Or let a profile suggest a game when it's ready: in the profile's **Name, look & options...**, tick **Suggest a game when this profile is ready**.
- Or give it a hotkey (see Hotkeys) or a button (see Stream Deck and other button pads).

Use it

1. Type part of a game's name to find it (or use the arrow keys).
2. Double-click the game, or press **Enter**. It starts, and the picker closes.

Click **Not now** (or press **Esc**) to close it without playing.

Your games

- Installed **Steam** and **Epic** games show up by themselves.
- **+ Add game...** adds any other game by its program or shortcut.
- Right-click a game to **Add to favorites** (favorites come first), **Hide from this list**, or **Remove** a game you added.
- Tick **Show hidden** to see hidden games again.
- Games you played most recently come right after your favorites.

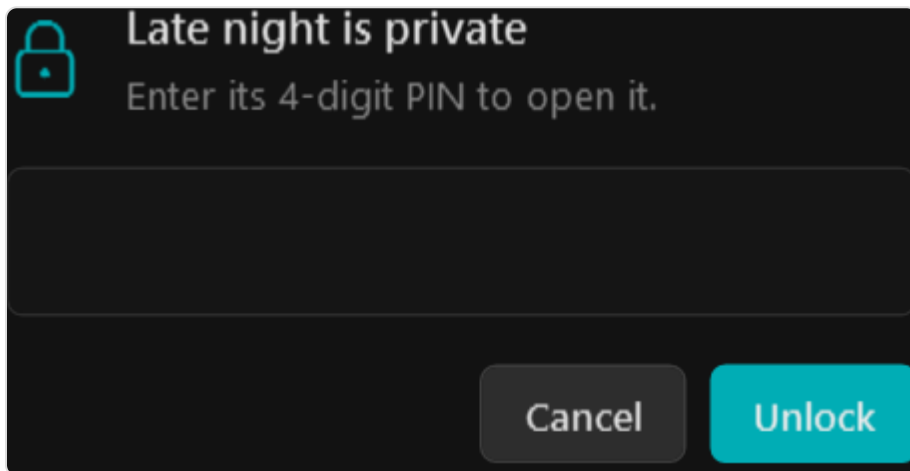
Private profiles (PIN)

A private profile needs a 4-digit PIN before anyone can open, close, edit, copy, export or delete it.

Make a profile private

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Name, look & options....**
2. Tick **Private profile**.
3. Type a 4-digit PIN, then type it again in the **Again** box.
4. Click **Save profile**.

The card now shows a lock and hides its list of apps.



Typing the PIN to unlock a private profile

Good to know

- After 5 wrong tries, the profile is locked for 60 seconds.
- Buttons and hotkeys still work: LaunchStage pops up the PIN box when you press them.
- **Change the PIN:** type a new one twice in **Name, look & options...** and save. Leave both boxes empty to keep the old one.
- **Stop it being private:** untick **Private profile** and save.

Tip: Forgot the PIN? It can't be recovered (LaunchStage only keeps a scrambled copy). Delete the profile's file from the Profiles folder (**Settings** > **Open profiles folder**) and make the profile again.

Settings and look

Click **Settings** at the top of the LaunchStage window (or right-click the tray icon, then **Settings**).

General

- ☒ Start with Windows (waits quietly in the tray)
- ☒ Show the tray icon (closing the window keeps LaunchStage ready)
- ☐ Red-green (deuteranopia) vision assist

Look ?

Colors

- ☒ Dark
- ☐ Light
- ☐ Match Windows

Launcher layout

- ☒ Cards
- ☐ Small cards
- ☐ List
- ☐ Big tiles

Admin support ?

- ☐ Run LaunchStage with administrator rights

Lets LaunchStage move and close apps that run as administrator, and start apps marked 'Run as administrator' without a prompt each time. Windows asks for permission once. Your other apps still start as normal apps.

Off: apps that run as administrator can't be moved or closed.

After a profile finishes, LaunchStage

- ☒ Goes to the tray
- ☐ Minimizes
- ☐ Stays open

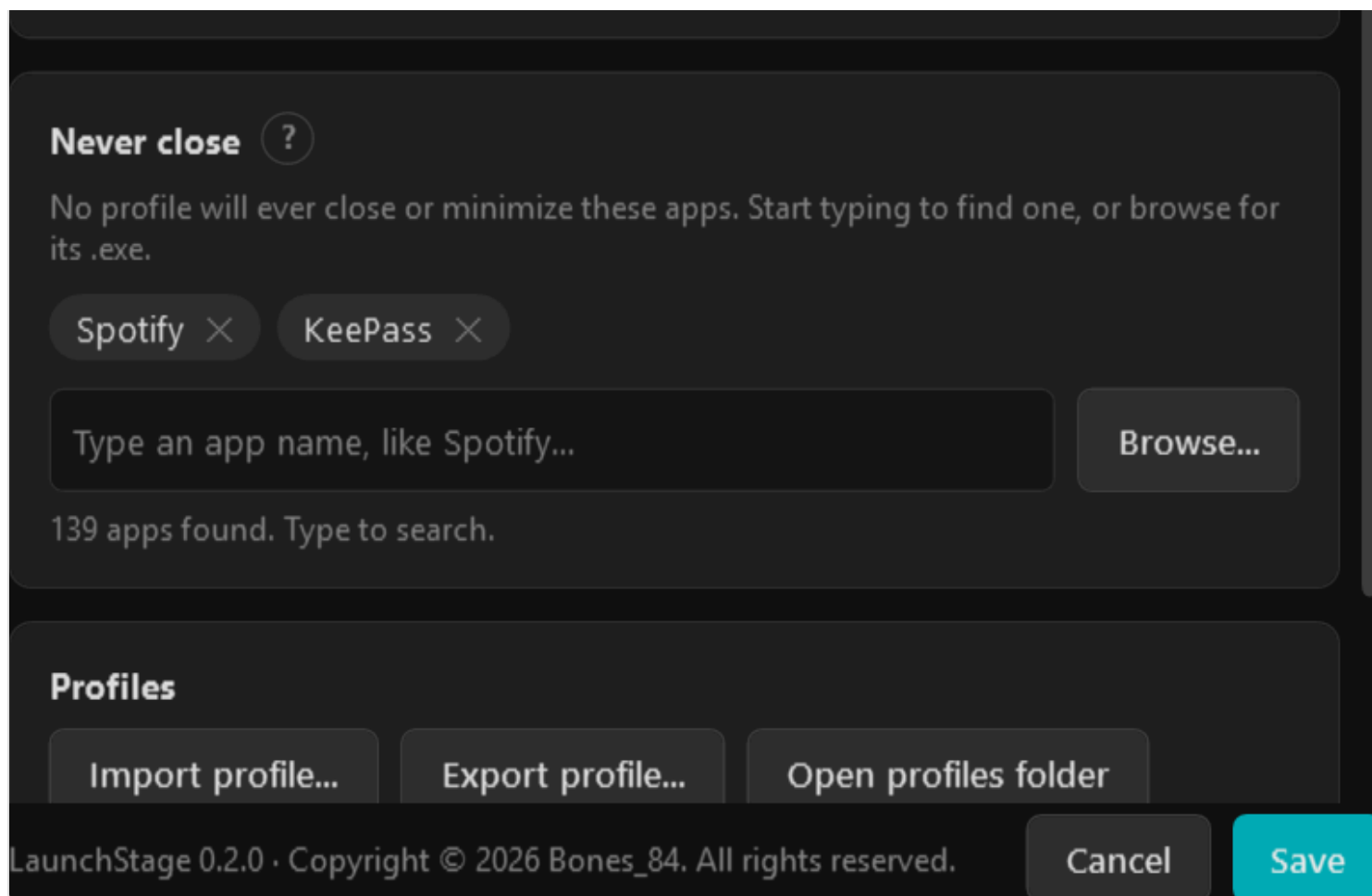
Hotkeys ?

Open the game picker

Ctrl+Alt+G

Clear

Click the box and press the keys. Each profile's own hotkeys are in its Name, look & options window.



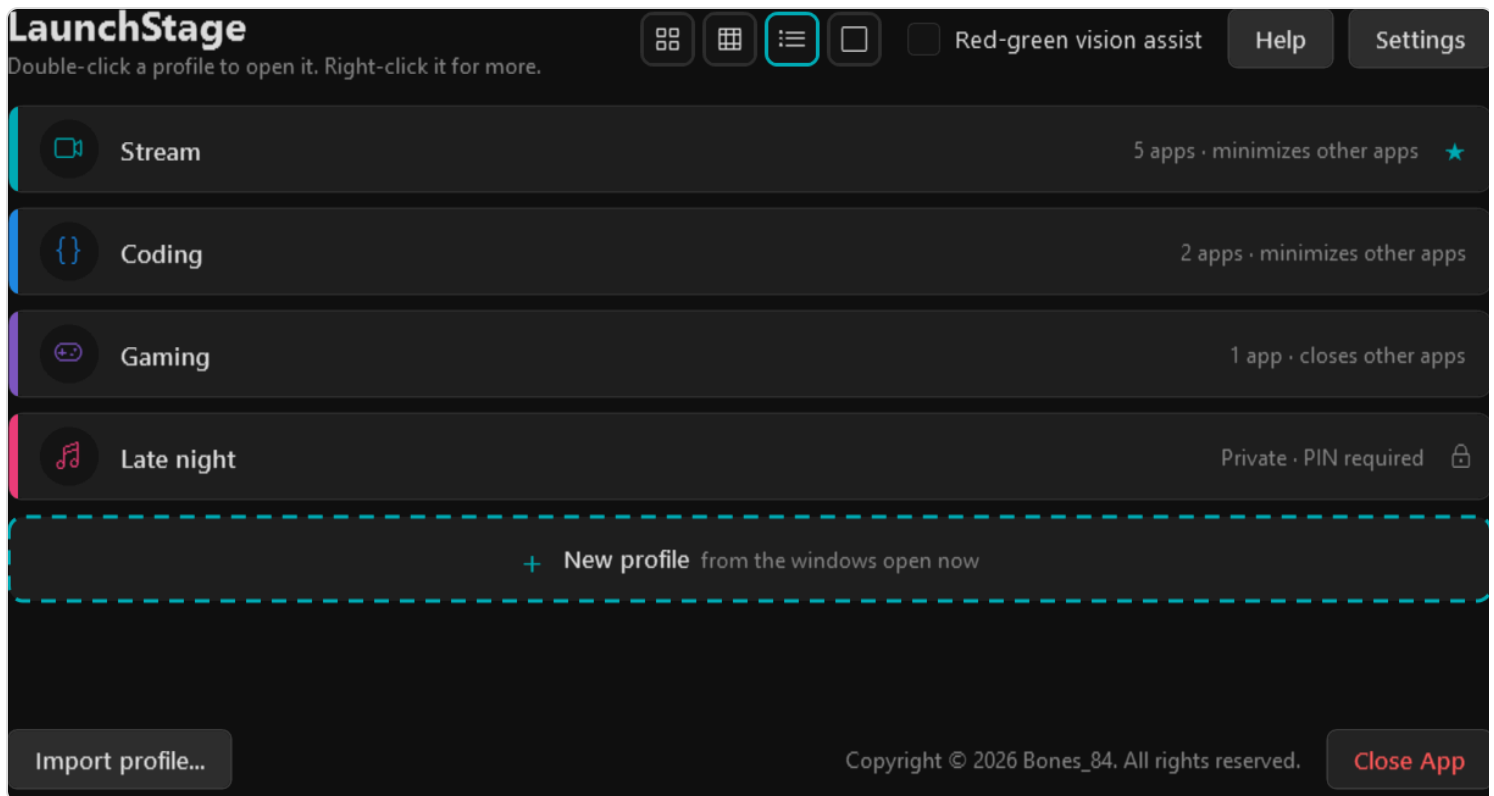
The Settings window

General

- **Start with Windows:** LaunchStage waits quietly in the tray after you sign in.
- **Show the tray icon:** with it on, closing the window keeps LaunchStage ready in the tray. **Close App** at the bottom of the window exits completely.
- **Red-green (deuteranopia) vision assist:** swaps red and green for colors that are easier to tell apart: blue means good, yellow means warning, orange means problem.

Look

- **Colors:** **Dark**, **Light**, or **Match Windows** (follows your Windows light or dark setting).
- **Launcher layout:** **Cards**, **Small cards**, **List** or **Big tiles**. The four small buttons at the top of the LaunchStage window switch this in one click.



The List layout: one row per profile

Admin support

Apps that run as administrator can only be moved or closed by a program that also has administrator rights. Tick **Run LaunchStage with administrator rights** and Windows asks for permission once. Your other apps still start as normal apps.

The other sections

- **After a profile finishes, LaunchStage:** goes to the tray, minimizes, or stays open.
- **Hotkeys:** the game picker hotkey (see Hotkeys).
- **Never close:** apps no profile will ever close (see Which apps close).
- **Profiles:** import or export profiles, open the profiles folder, or open the log.

Click **Save** to keep your changes.

Remove LaunchStage

LaunchStage doesn't need installing, but it does add a few things to your PC (like starting with Windows). To take it all away again, don't just delete its folder:

1. Open **Settings** and, at the bottom, click **Remove LaunchStage....** (Or double-click **Uninstall LaunchStage.cmd** in the LaunchStage folder.)
2. To keep your profiles, untick **Also delete my profiles, settings and game history.**
3. Click **Remove LaunchStage**. If you used Admin support, Windows asks for permission once.

LaunchStage closes, and a few seconds later its files and folder are gone. It only deletes its own files, never anything else in that folder.

Tip: Using the Stream Deck plugin? Remove it in the Stream Deck app: **Preferences, Plugins**, pick **LaunchStage**, then click the minus button.

When something goes wrong

A window didn't go to the right spot

1. Right-click the profile's card and click **Put windows back**.
2. Still wrong? Click **Edit layout & apps...**, click the app, and check its **Monitor** and position. **Move it there now** lets you try the spot.

Some apps move themselves right after opening. LaunchStage puts them back a few seconds later, so give it a moment.

An app didn't open

- "...its window didn't appear": the app took longer than usual. In **Edit layout & apps...**, click the app and raise **Give up waiting after (seconds)**.
- "...didn't open": the program file may have moved (apps like Discord change folders when they update). In **Edit layout & apps...**, click the app, then **Browse...** to pick its program again.

An app didn't close

- The corner box asks what to do: **Try again**, **Leave it open & continue** or **Stop profile**.
- "...it's running as administrator": turn on **Admin support** in **Settings**.

A game isn't in the game picker

Click + **Add game...** in the game picker and pick the game's program or shortcut.

Get help from someone

LaunchStage writes everything it does to a log file. It's the best thing to send when asking for help.

1. Open **Settings**.
2. Click **Open log** (under **Profiles**).
3. Copy the last part of the log, or send the whole file.

The log is in `%AppData%\LaunchStage\Logs\debug_log.txt`.

Tip: Exclusive-fullscreen games can't be moved by any program. Set the game to **borderless windowed** in its own settings.

